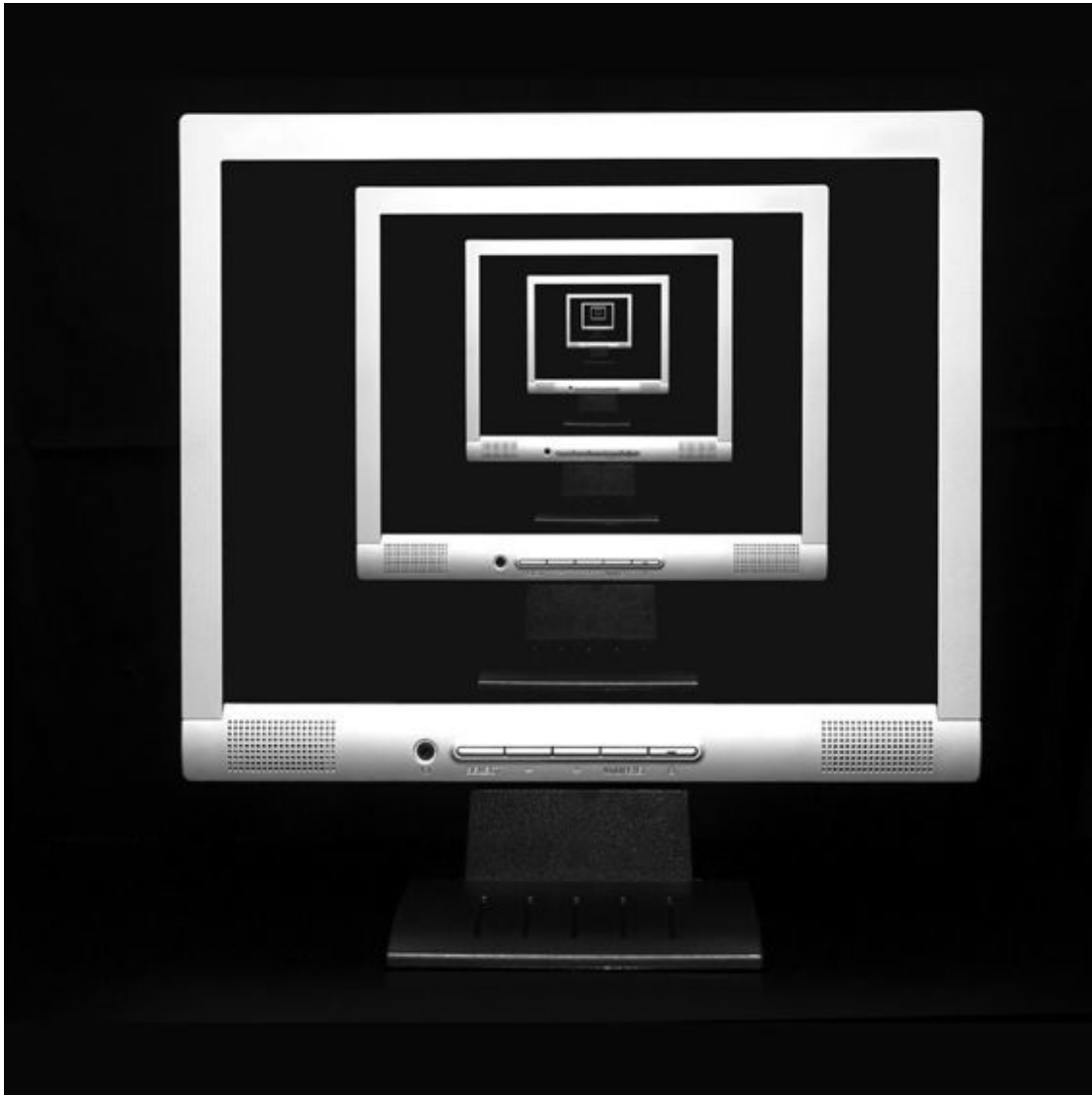


Infinite regress



The idea of a screen within a screen within a screen, like an infinite series of reflections, embodies the troublesome concept of infinite regress.

The argument Anaximander used to challenge his teacher's theory of the Earth floating on water involved an idea that crops up in several strands of philosophy. If the world is supported by a body of water, then what supports the water? And then, what supports *that*? And so on, *ad infinitum*. The same pattern can be seen in arguments involving cause and effect: if something causes something else, then what caused *that*? This apparently unending

chain is called an infinite regress. Some philosophers saw the existence of infinite regress as proof that the universe is eternal, but many were uncomfortable with the idea and proposed that there must be an original or first cause for everything (an idea that chimes with the modern theory of the Big Bang). For some, the first cause or 'prime mover' was an abstract idea akin to pure thought or reason, but, for medieval Christian philosophers especially, it was God: indeed, the idea of a first cause was at the heart of Thomas Aquinas's cosmological argument for the existence of God (see [Existence of God: the cosmological argument](#)).